

When Vista was codenamed Longhorn, one of the features that were touted for it was a complete overhaul of the underlying file system. So much so that it would make a complete break with the way data was managed—WinFS, as the new file system was then named, aimed to take data out of the dark ages of a tree and folder structure into a new dawn that was a system built around a relational database. Such a system would therefore relate multiple points of data and metadata with each file and the data would essentially be fetched through a query, much like content is accessed in databases. WinFS was perhaps too drastic a departure from the norm, or perhaps Microsoft simply decided to drop the feature to rein in the slipping release date of Windows Longhorn.

Vista, however, manages to juggle the old with the new. While it still ships with the NTFS file system, it makes a break from the FAT and FAT32 files of Windows XP days—now Vista requires an NTFS partition to install itself. It also introduces the concept of tagging and metadata to sort and file your personal data. Finally, it ties these pieces together with a pervasive indexing service and a search feature that leverages the index in multiple places and in interesting ways. Let's take a look at how data is managed under Windows Vista, starting with folder and file management and then on to program and service management.

9.1 Folder Management

Not much has changed with Vista and folders. The biggest addition is that Vista now allows symbolic links to both directories and files—these links are represented with the same arrow used to denote a shortcut. A symbolic link to a resource merely points to the destination and can therefore be removed without deleting the destination folder or file.

A symbolic link is thus merely a pointer to the actual location of a data. Under Windows 2000, directories had symbolic links and were called directory junctions, but it is with the advent of Vista